Political Discontent and Regime Instability

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Data Availability Statement

Replication data is available on the Harvard Dataverse [link tbd], and the work's complete revision history is available at https://github.com/fsolt/trust_stability.

Political Discontent and Regime Instability

abstract

Measuring Regime Instability

Testing whether political discontent undermines regime stability requires a cross-national, country-year measure of instability, and here the quantitative literature offers not one standard but several distinct traditions. Researchers have operationalized regime instability as discrete regime breakdowns, as the survival and manner of exit of individual leaders, as counts of coups and other contentious events, as composite indices of state fragility, and as change in continuous measures of regime characteristics. These operationalizations are not interchangeable: they capture different phenomena, diverge sharply in practice, and can lead the same explanatory variable to opposite conclusions depending on which is chosen (Hollyer, Rosendorff, and Vreeland 2015). Our choice of outcome measure therefore demands explicit justification.

The first tradition treats instability as discrete regime breakdown. In this work, a regime is defined by the basic formal and informal rules that determine who may hold power and whose interests constrain the leadership, and a breakdown is coded when those rules change, whether or not the successor regime is any more democratic (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014). The Geddes, Wright, and Frantz data identify 280 autocratic regimes between 1946 and 2010 and code, for each collapse, its mode—electoral defeat, military coup, popular uprising, insurgency, foreign imposition, or elite-imposed rule change—and its violence (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014). The Historical Regimes Data extend this rules-based conception from 1789 to 2016 and, applying lower thresholds, identify 925 regimes over the span in which Geddes, Wright, and Frantz count

280—a threefold divergence demonstrating that breakdown counts are highly sensitive to conceptual choices (Djuve, Knutsen, and Wig 2020). Earlier practice instead inferred regime change from threshold crossings on the Polity scale (Marshall and Gurr 2020), but such proxies overstate autocratic regime survival by fully 100 percent (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014). Related work built on V-Dem identifies episodes of regime transformation: sustained movements on the electoral democracy index that terminate, or not, in transitions between democracy and autocracy, yielding a discrete country-year transition variable with built-in guards against coding mere measurement noise as regime change (Maerz et al. 2024).

A second tradition locates instability in leaders rather than regimes. The Archigos data code the entry and exit of national leaders in 188 states from 1875 to 2004, distinguishing regular transfers from irregular removals—about one exit in five—accomplished in contravention of established rules, typically by coup, revolt, or assassination (Goemans, Gleditsch, and Chiozza 2009). Leader-survival measures power hazard models of autocratic politics (Svolik 2012; Hollyer, Rosendorff, and Vreeland 2015). Yet fewer than half of postwar autocratic leadership changes coincided with regime change, and substituting leader change for regime change understates autocratic stability by roughly 50 percent (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014).

A third tradition counts contentious events. The most widely used coup data cover all attempts, successful and failed, from 1950 onward (Powell and Thyne 2011), and more recent work distinguishes coups that merely reshuffle the leadership from those that change the regime, showing that pooled coup counts conflate distinct instability processes (Chin, Carter, and Wright 2021). Protest and unrest counts—the Cross-National Time-Series domestic conflict series (Banks and Wilson 2022) and the Mass Mobilization data (Clark and Regan 2021)—capture mass contention short of breakdown. Media-sourced event counts, however, suffer systematic reporting bias: fewer than a third of ground-truth violent events appear in the international news sources on which these datasets rely, and because the probability of reporting is correlated with covariates of interest, this bias is capable of producing entirely spurious regression results (Weidmann 2016).

A fourth tradition constructs composite indices. The Political Instability Task Force pools civil wars, adverse regime changes, genocides, and politicides into consolidated "instability onsets" (Goldstone et al. 2010), while donor agencies produce state fragility

indices that aggregate security, economic, and institutional indicators into single rankings. Methodological reviews conclude that these holistic indices build the assumed causes and consequences of instability into the measure itself and so advise against their use as variables in regression analysis (Gutiérrez Sanín 2011; Ziaja 2012).

The final tradition—and the one in which this paper's research design is rooted—measures instability as change in continuous regime characteristics. Claassen (2020) models democratic survival as annual change in the V-Dem liberal democracy index, explicitly rejecting categorical alternatives on measurement-error grounds; this approach captures the gradual erosion and backsliding that now outnumber sudden breakdowns, which threshold-based measures are prone to misclassify (Lührmann, Tannenberg, and Lindberg 2018). Crucially for our purposes, the V-Dem measurement model quantifies the uncertainty of its regime estimates (Coppedge et al. 2024), and nearly a third of countries in recent years occupy regime categories that are ambiguous once that uncertainty is taken into account (Lührmann, Tannenberg, and Lindberg 2018). Tai, Hu, and Solt (2024) demonstrate what is at stake in ignoring such uncertainty: incorporating the measurement uncertainty of latent public-opinion estimates overturns the conclusion that public support predicts democratic survival.

We accordingly measure regime instability primarily as annual change in the V-Dem democracy indices. This choice maximizes temporal overlap with our discontent estimates, whose identifying survey data are concentrated in the past three decades; it retains statistical power that rare breakdown events cannot provide in a survey-limited panel; it captures the regime erosion characteristic of the contemporary period; and it allows us to propagate measurement uncertainty on both sides of the equation, consistent with our method-of-composition estimation strategy. To ensure that our conclusions are not artifacts of this choice, we also examine discrete regime transitions from the Episodes of Regime Transformation data (Maerz et al. 2024) as an alternative operationalization.

Coauthor Guide – Findings & Framing

❗ READ BEFORE DRAFTING – what the results are, what we can and cannot claim (JC, 2026-07-29; numbers = final full rerun)

TL;DR. Across ~170 model cells (four regime-event codings, two estimators, all with method-of-composition uncertainty propagation over 900 posterior draws), the results form a **mirror asymmetry**:

> **Public discontent destabilizes autocracies; public support stabilizes democracies; neither works the other way around.** Discontent among publics in autocracies precedes both the *onset* of regime-change episodes and *completed democratization* (DD and BMR codings). Support among publics in democracies lowers the hazard that erosion episodes *begin*. Discontent never predicts democratic breakdown under any operationalization, and support never protects autocracies.

This is the sentence the theory, introduction, and conclusion should be built around. Full results: Tables 1–4 and the battery figure below (Results section); every estimated model is in `output/tables_appendix_all_models.docx`.

Key numbers (MOC, final rerun). Episode onset, regime split (Table 2B): discontent in autocracies +.047–.048, p = .010/.021; support in democracies -.034/-.036, p = .011/.012; both cross-terms null (p = .50–.64). Draw-wise asymmetry tests: support p = .046/.049, discontent p = .062/.065. Completed transitions, democratization side (Table 3B/D): DD p = .033/.035, BMR p = .007/.010 (BMR within-coding asymmetry p = .010–.035 in all four cells); breakdown side null everywhere (p = .44–.83).

What we CAN claim.

1. Discontent precedes the *start* of regime-change processes, concentrated among publics in autocracies (Table 2, Panel B).
2. Discontent precedes *completed democratization* under turnover-based dichotomous codings (DD, BMR), with the democratization-vs-breakdown asymmetry formally significant in BMR.
3. Support protects democracies at the episode-onset stage (additive main effect).

4. Discontent does not predict democratic breakdown under any of the four codings, nor erosion-episode onset – a strong, multiply-operationalized null that speaks directly against the "discontent kills democracy" narrative.
5. Naive analysis overstates certainty: naive-significant cells die under MOC; the surviving claims are exactly those robust to measurement uncertainty.

What we must NOT claim (guardrails).

- No buffering / "critical citizens" conditional claims: the discontent-x-support interaction is directionally consistent but uniformly null under MOC (tested throughout; archived). Support's protection is *additive*.
- "Precedes democratization," not "causes democratization": observational 1-year-lead evidence. ERT completion cells are null – discontent knocks on the door; other forces open it.
- The completion result is **coding-conditional**: turnover-based dichotomies (DD, BMR) yes; ERT index-threshold transitions and GWF regime cases no. Not a contradiction – the event-overlap audit (Table 4) shows the codings share only ~25–45% of their "democratization" events. Say which definitions carry the result.
- Do not headline the pooled any-onset (all regimes) cell: it sits in a borderline band (MOC p = .035–.060) because it pools the strong autocratic signal with the null democratic one. The regime-split cell (Table 2, Panel B) is the main evidence.
- GWF cells and the liberalization-onset cell are exploratory (5–18 events). Regime-split GMM estimates but fails its own diagnostics (Sargan/AR(2)) in every instrument window probed – cautionary, appendix only.

Pointers per section.

- *Theory/framing*: mass opinion erodes the status-quo regime with regime-type-asymmetric consequences – Welzel-style aspirations push autocracies toward democracy; Easton/Claassen-style diffuse support keeps democracies from starting to erode. The two null cells are theoretically load-bearing: discontent does not kill democracies (contra Foa/Mounk), and popular support does not save autocracies.

- *Literature*: `paper/lit_review_regime_stability.md` is complete and web-verified – no opinion-IV study uses event DVs; none of the 18 canonical stability-DV studies includes mass opinion.
- *Introduction*: lead with the doom narrative, then report that the threat is real but points the other way – at autocracies.
- *Conclusion*: measurement matters twice – uncertainty propagation (naive vs MOC) and event definitions (the overlap audit); both are portable lessons.
- *Data/Methods/Results*: JC (drafted below). Numbers regenerate from `codes/final_01_master.R` (estimation) and `final_02`–`final_05` (tables/figure); do not hand-edit result numbers.

Literature

A test of citation (Claassen 2019; **?**).

Theory

Political Discontent and Regime (In)stability

Data and Measurement

0.1 Public political discontent and democratic support

Our focal predictor is public political discontent (PPD), the latent country-year estimate introduced in (**?**): a Bayesian latent-variable model (DCPO; (**?**)) that pools [N] survey items on political dissatisfaction across [K] countries. Because the estimates carry measurement uncertainty, we retain 900 draws from the posterior rather than point estimates. Democratic support is measured analogously with the Claassen-style support mood (**?**; **?**), also as 900 paired posterior draws. Both scales run 0–100. Country-years before a country's first actual survey are dropped (the published trim rule), removing backward extrapolation from the estimation sample. The analysis window is effectively 1988–2019, bounded by the survey base and the control series.

0.2 Regime-change outcomes

Our theory concerns regime change, not movements in democratic quality. We therefore measure outcomes as discrete regime events, and – because event codings embody consequential definitional choices – we use four canonical datasets rather than one:

1. **V-Dem ERT / Regimes of the World** (**?**): (a) *episode onset*, the first year of a democratization or autocratization episode (a sustained, substantial movement of the electoral-democracy index), with the risk set excluding ongoing-episode years; and (b) *category change*, any move among the four Regimes-of-the-World classes, including the democracy–autocracy boundary crossing.
2. **DD/ACLP** in the Bjornskov–Rode update (**?**), which extends Cheibub–Gandhi–Vreeland coverage to the mid-2020s: democratization and democratic breakdown on the contestation-plus-alternation dichotomy.
3. **Boix–Miller–Rosato** (**?**): the same two events on the Boix-lineage dichotomy (1800–2020).
4. **Geddes–Wright–Frantz** (**?**) regime cases (supplementary: coverage ends 2010, leaving 16 in-sample boundary events).

All events follow one convention: the event year is the **final year of the outgoing regime** (lead-coded where the source codes the new regime's first year), so that covariates measured in the event year precede the transition itself. Each coding contributes its own duration clock (its native regime-spell age) and its own transition-history control (the count of prior transitions under its own definition, which by construction never includes the event being modeled). As we document in the Results (Table 4), the codings capture substantially different event populations, which motivates the multi-coding design and disciplines interpretation.

0.3 Controls

The full specification carries nine controls: the five from Claassen's (2020) design (log GDP per capita, GDP growth, regional democracy levels, percent Muslim, resource dependence; the first two and the last are multiply imputed in the source, and the imputation draws are paired with the opinion draws), the two robust determinants from the extreme-bounds analysis of Gassebner, Lamla, and Vreeland (**?**) that the Claassen set lacks (prior

transitions and OECD membership), plus income inequality (SWIID 9.8; (**?**)) and log population (World Bank).

Empirical Strategy

0.1 Propagating measurement uncertainty

Every model is estimated twice. The *naive* version uses posterior-mean data, as is standard practice. The *method-of-composition* (MOC) version re-estimates the model on each of the 900 draw-datasets, samples one coefficient vector from each fitted model's sampling distribution, and summarizes the resulting 900 draws: the point estimate is the draw mean and the standard error the draw standard deviation, so reported uncertainty combines sampling and measurement components (**?**; **?**). Interaction and derived quantities (marginal effects, slope differences) are computed draw-wise, preserving the coefficient covariance. Products for the naive data are rebuilt from averaged components, since the mean of products is not the product of means.

0.2 Dynamic panel

To anchor the analysis in the existing literature we first estimate Claassen's (2020) specification with the democracy *level* as outcome:

$$D_{it} = \alpha + \sum_{k=1}^{2} \phi_k D_{i,t-k} + \beta\, \theta_{i,t-1} + \gamma\, S_{i,t-1} + \mathbf{X}_{i,t-1}\delta + \varepsilon_{it}$$

for V-Dem liberal and electoral democracy, by pooled OLS (panel-corrected standard errors) and system GMM (one-step, levels-and-differences), using Claassen's instrument lag window (3–5) with collapsed instrument columns – our panel is more complete than the original, so the uncollapsed set over-instruments (Sargan pinned at 1.000). A regime-split variant enters discontent and support as zero-filled interactions with a Regimes-of-the-World democracy dummy. The regime-split GMM variant is estimated for completeness but treated as cautionary only: its overidentification and serial-correlation tests reject in every instrument window probed, its lagged-DV coefficients imply explosive dynamics, and its coefficients flip sign across specifications – the signature of a misspecified mean equation rather than of any estimable effect (Appendix [X]).

0.3 Discrete-time hazards

Events are rare and binary, so persistence is handled by a duration baseline rather than lagged outcomes: we estimate discrete-time hazard logits with the coding's native regime age and its square, the coding's transition-history count, and the nine controls. Every cell is estimated by both plain maximum likelihood with country-clustered standard errors and Firth penalized likelihood (**?**); divergence between the two flags small-sample fragility, and we report both throughout. Timing follows a uniform one-year opinion-precedes-outcome rule: boundary-crossing events are lead-coded, so current-year covariates precede the transition; episode-onset events occur within the year, so the entire right-hand side is lagged one year.

Our central specification splits the opinion slopes by regime type within one pooled hazard. With $R_{i,t-1}$ an indicator for democracy (each coding's own classification for its own cells),

$$\Pr(Y_{it}=1)=\Lambda(\beta_a\theta_{i,t-1}(1-R)+\beta_d\theta_{i,t-1}R+\gamma_a S_{i,t-1}(1-R)+\gamma_d S_{i,t-1}R+\lambda R+f(\text{age}_{it})+\mathbf{X}\delta)$$

This is the zero-filled full-interaction parameterization of the dynamic-panel literature transplanted to the hazard setting: regime-specific opinion slopes share one baseline hazard and one control block, which preserves events-per- variable in the rare-events cells, and – because both slopes sit in one model – permits a formal test of regime asymmetry as the draw-wise distribution of $\hat{\beta}_a - \hat{\beta}_d$.

Results

0.1 Public opinion does not move annual democracy levels

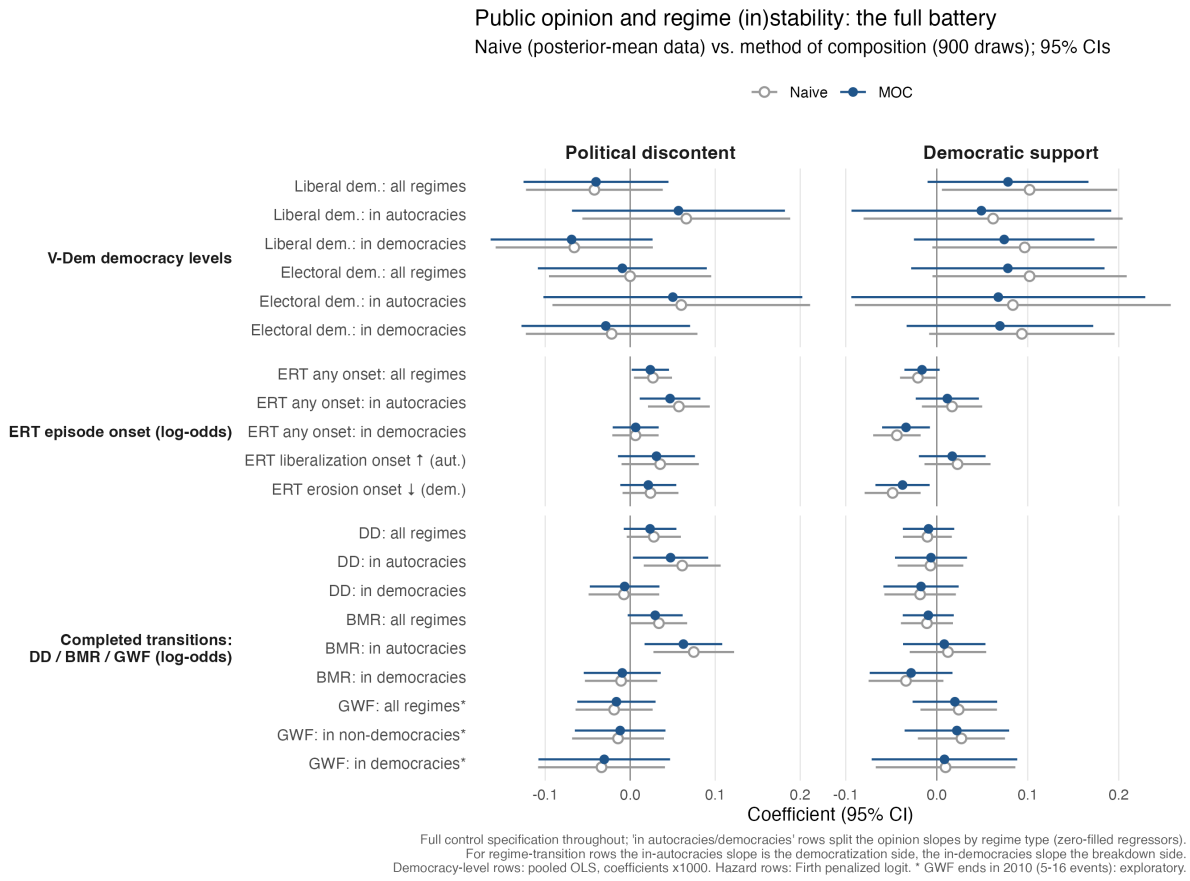


Figure 1: The full battery at a glance: focal coefficients with 95% confidence intervals, naive (posterior-mean data, open grey) vs. method of composition (900 draws, solid blue). Top: pooled-OLS democracy-level models with regime-split opinion slopes (x1000). Middle: ERT episode-onset hazards (split IVs, Firth). Bottom: completed democracy-boundary crossings under DD/BMR/GWF (split IVs, Firth; GWF exploratory, coverage ends 2010).

Table 1: Table 1. Public opinion and annual democracy-index change (dynamic panel, full specification). Coefficients x1000.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.042	(0.305)	-0.040	0.043	(0.355)	NA
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.102**	(0.038)	0.078+	0.045	(0.083)	NA
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	System GMM	-0.034	(0.395)	-0.030	0.043	(0.488)	NA
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	System GMM	0.093	(0.122)	0.058	0.062	(0.348)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.066	(0.290)	0.057	0.064	(0.375)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.066	(0.163)	-0.069	0.049	(0.156)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.062	(0.394)	0.049	0.073	(0.501)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.097+	(0.062)	0.074	0.051	(0.143)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.386+	(0.054)	0.391**	0.195	(0.045)	NA

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	-0.117	(0.461)	-0.122	0.160	(0.445)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.051	(0.811)	0.090	0.200	(0.653)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	-0.735***	(0.006)	-0.612***	0.232	(0.008)	NA
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.000	(0.998)	-0.009	0.051	(0.856)	NA
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.102+	(0.061)	0.078	0.054	(0.149)	NA
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	System GMM	-0.007	(0.872)	-0.022	0.055	(0.688)	NA
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	System GMM	0.090	(0.130)	0.052	0.066	(0.430)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.060	(0.437)	0.050	0.078	(0.518)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.022	(0.672)	-0.029	0.051	(0.570)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.084	(0.345)	0.068	0.082	(0.412)	NA

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.094+	(0.072)	0.069	0.052	(0.185)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.077	(0.697)	0.149	0.199	(0.452)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	-0.441**	(0.027)	-0.399**	0.193	(0.038)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.080	(0.728)	0.116	0.240	(0.629)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	-0.889***	(0.005)	-0.730**	0.286	(0.011)	NA

Table 1 reports the dynamic-panel results. Discontent is null in every valid cell (MOC $p = .16$–$.86$). Support reproduces the pattern documented by (**?**): naive-significant in pooled OLS ($p = .04$–$.06$), attenuating to marginal or null once measurement uncertainty is propagated ($p = .08$–$.50$). Under the full specification, no opinion variable robustly predicts year-to-year movement in democracy indices. If public opinion matters for regimes, it does not operate through marginal annual changes in democratic quality – motivating the shift to discrete regime events.

0.2 Discontent starts regime-change episodes – in autocracies

Table 2: Table 2. Public opinion and the onset of V-Dem ERT regime-change episodes (discrete-time hazard, full specification). Log-odds per point of the 0-100 opinion scales.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.027**	(0.040)	0.024+	0.013	(0.060)	90
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.027**	(0.019)	0.024**	0.011	(0.035)	90
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Logit	-0.021**	(0.039)	-0.016+	0.010	(0.097)	90
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Firth	-0.021**	(0.039)	-0.016	0.010	(0.102)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Logit	0.059***	(0.005)	0.048**	0.021	(0.021)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Firth	0.057***	(0.002)	0.047**	0.018	(0.010)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Logit	0.007	(0.644)	0.007	0.014	(0.614)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Firth	0.006	(0.655)	0.006	0.014	(0.640)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Logit	0.017	(0.318)	0.012	0.018	(0.504)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Firth	0.017	(0.320)	0.012	0.018	(0.510)	90

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Logit	-0.045***	(0.002)	-0.036**	0.014	(0.012)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Firth	-0.044***	(0.001)	-0.034**	0.013	(0.011)	90
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.041**	(0.040)	0.033+	0.020	(0.092)	32
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.038**	(0.047)	0.031	0.019	(0.108)	32
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	0.003	(0.889)	0.001	0.019	(0.959)	32
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	0.002	(0.900)	0.001	0.017	(0.939)	32
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.018	(0.348)	0.016	0.019	(0.394)	58
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.017	(0.227)	0.016	0.014	(0.268)	58
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	-0.048***	(0.004)	-0.037**	0.015	(0.017)	58
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	-0.046***	(0.001)	-0.036**	0.014	(0.010)	58
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.040+	(0.056)	0.033	0.025	(0.172)	18
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.035	(0.128)	0.031	0.023	(0.182)	18

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	0.025	(0.248)	-0.018	0.021	(0.381)	18
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	0.023	(0.218)	-0.017	0.019	(0.364)	18
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.025	(0.208)	0.021	0.019	(0.268)	42
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.024	(0.154)	0.021	0.017	(0.206)	42
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	-0.050***	(0.006)	-0.039**	0.017	(0.020)	42
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	-0.049***	(0.002)	-0.038**	0.015	(0.014)	42

Table 2, Panel B contains the paper's central estimates. Among publics in autocracies, discontent measured at $t-1$ raises the hazard that a regime-change episode begins at t: the MOC estimate is .047–.048 log-odds per scale point ($p = .010/.021$ by Firth and plain logit respectively) – roughly a **70% increase in the odds of episode onset per standard deviation of discontent** (11.6 points). The same quantity for publics in democracies is precisely zero ($p = .61$–$.64$). Support shows the mirror image: protective among publics in democracies (odds ratio per SD ≈ 0.67; $p = .011/.012$), null among publics in autocracies. The formal asymmetry tests confirm the pattern: the support asymmetry is significant ($p = .046/.049$), the discontent asymmetry marginal ($p = .062/.065$), in both estimators.

Panels C and D re-estimate the any-onset hazard within each regime subsample (single pooled slope, own baseline and controls): directionally consistent with the split estimates,

at conventional significance only where events are plentiful. Panels E and F probe direction. The liberalization-onset cell (autocracies only, 18 events) is directionally positive but underpowered. The erosion-onset cell (democracies, 42 events) is the doom narrative's best chance to appear – discontent predicting the *start* of democratic erosion – and it is null ($p = .21$–$.27$), while support's protective effect persists ($p = .014$–$.020$).

0.3 Discontent precedes completed democratization – under turnover-based codings

Table 3: Table 3. Public opinion and completed regime transitions across canonical codings (discrete-time hazard, split IVs, full specification). Log-odds.

			Naive	Naive		MOC	MOC		
Model	Variable	Estimator	b	p		b	se	p	Events
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Logit	0.030	(0.119)		0.025	0.019	(0.191)	36
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Firth	0.028	+ (0.087)		0.023	0.016	(0.140)	36
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Logit	-0.010	(0.562)		-0.009	0.018	(0.624)	36
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Firth	-0.010	(0.452)		-0.009	0.014	(0.529)	36
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Logit	0.066	** (0.010)		0.053	** 0.025	(0.033)	36
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Firth	0.061	** (0.008)		0.048	** 0.023	(0.035)	36
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.006	(0.785)		-0.005	0.024	(0.830)	36
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.007	(0.727)		-0.007	0.021	(0.754)	36
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Logit	-0.006	(0.779)		-0.006	0.021	(0.762)	36

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Firth	-0.007	(0.707)	-0.006	0.020	(0.753)	36
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Logit	-0.019	(0.436)	-0.017	0.025	(0.489)	36
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Firth	-0.018	(0.361)	-0.017	0.021	(0.411)	36
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Logit	0.036**	(0.045)	0.030+	0.018	(0.099)	31
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Firth	0.034**	(0.046)	0.029+	0.016	(0.074)	31
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Logit	-0.011	(0.535)	-0.009	0.016	(0.569)	31
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Firth	-0.011	(0.459)	-0.009	0.014	(0.513)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Logit	0.080***	(0.002)	0.070***	0.027	(0.010)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Firth	0.075***	(0.002)	0.063***	0.023	(0.007)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.010	(0.682)	-0.008	0.024	(0.739)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.011	(0.622)	-0.009	0.023	(0.685)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Logit	0.013	(0.561)	0.009	0.024	(0.713)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Firth	0.012	(0.566)	0.008	0.023	(0.722)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Logit	-0.035	(0.247)	-0.031	0.029	(0.284)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Firth	-0.034	(0.107)	-0.028	0.023	(0.224)	31

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Discontent	Logit	-0.019	(0.508)	-0.015	0.028	(0.576)	16
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Discontent	Firth	-0.019	(0.414)	-0.016	0.024	(0.490)	16
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Support	Logit	0.028	(0.301)	0.024	0.029	(0.413)	16
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Support	Firth	0.024	(0.261)	0.020	0.024	(0.401)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in non-democracies	Logit	-0.013	(0.728)	-0.008	0.036	(0.827)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in non-democracies	Firth	-0.014	(0.604)	-0.012	0.027	(0.664)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.034	(0.460)	-0.027	0.047	(0.568)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.034	(0.376)	-0.030	0.040	(0.441)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in non-democracies	Logit	0.032	(0.225)	0.027	0.032	(0.405)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in non-democracies	Firth	0.027	(0.267)	0.022	0.029	(0.450)	16

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in democracies	Logit	0.012	(0.860)	0.011	0.062	(0.860)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in democracies	Firth	0.010	(0.805)	0.008	0.041	(0.836)	16

Table 3 applies the same split design to each coding's own democracy boundary. The democratization-side slope – discontent among publics in autocracies – survives MOC under both dichotomous codings: DD ($p = .033$–$.035$) and BMR ($p = .007$–$.010$), the latter implying that a standard-deviation increase in discontent roughly **doubles the odds** that an autocracy completes a transition to democracy the following year. The breakdown-side slope is null in every coding ($p = .44$–$.83$), and the within-coding asymmetry test is significant in all four BMR cells ($p = .010$–$.035$). GWF, with 16 in-sample boundary events and coverage ending in 2010, shows nothing and is treated as exploratory.

Two qualifications discipline this result. First, it is coding-conditional: ERT's own boundary-crossing cells are null. The next subsection shows why this is not a contradiction. Second, the ERT severity gradient – onset significant, completion null – indicates that discontent's reliable footprint is at the *initiation* of regime change; whether initiated episodes complete depends on downstream forces our design does not model.

0.4 Different codings count different democratizations

Table 4: Table 4. Event overlap across codings, survey-covered sample. Cell entries: captured/eligible (%) – row-coding events with a counterpart in the column coding (same country, event years within +/-2). Eligible excludes row events outside the column coding's coverage window; only GWF binds (ends 2010, so its column counts row events through 2012).

Event	Coding Events	Captured by ERT	Captured by DD	Captured by BMR	Captured by GWF
Democratization	ERT 35	–	9/35 (26%)	6/35 (17%)	3/24 (12%)

Event	Coding	Events	Captured by ERT	Captured by DD	Captured by BMR	Captured by GWF
Democratization	DD	25	9/25 (36%)	–	6/25 (24%)	8/18 (44%)
Democratization	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	6/18 (33%)	–	5/12 (42%)
Democratization	GWF	12	3/12 (25%)	8/12 (67%)	5/12 (42%)	–
Breakdown	ERT	35	–	8/35 (23%)	6/35 (17%)	2/20 (10%)
Breakdown	DD	22	8/22 (36%)	–	10/22 (45%)	4/10 (40%)
Breakdown	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	10/18 (56%)	–	4/10 (40%)
Breakdown	GWF	6	2/6 (33%)	4/6 (67%)	4/6 (67%)	–

Why does discontent predict completed democratization under DD and BMR but not under ERT's boundary crossing? Because, to a degree rarely acknowledged, the four series are not alternative measurements of one event list – they are substantially different event lists. Table 4 makes this concrete: within the survey-covered sample, pairwise capture rates among the three democratization series run from 17% to 36%, and the breakdown side looks no better (17–56%). Even allowing a two-year dating window, roughly two of every three events in any one series have no counterpart in another.

The mismatches are systematic, not noise. Democratizations that only ERT records are predominantly index-threshold reclassifications within already-electoral regimes – countries crossing the electoral-autocracy / electoral-democracy line without a government turnover (e.g., Ukraine 2005, Kenya 2012, Mexico 1995, North Macedonia 2016). Democratizations that only the dichotomies record are turnover-type transitions – founding or alternation elections – where V-Dem's regime classification either had already moved or did not move within the window (e.g., Kyrgyzstan 2005, Thailand 2007, Taiwan 1999, Tunisia 2014). Read against Table 3, the pattern is informative rather than embarrassing: **public discontent precedes the turnover-type transitions that dichotomous codings are built to capture, not the incremental reclassifications that index thresholds register.** It also strengthens the breakdown null: discontent fails to predict democratic breakdown across three largely *distinct* event populations, not one list counted three ways.

0.5 What does not appear

Three null results are load-bearing. (1) **Democratic breakdown**: discontent predicts breakdown under none of the four codings, in no specification, by either estimator – and, per Table 2F, does not even predict the onset of erosion episodes. (2) **Conditional (buffering) effects**: the discontent-x-support interaction, estimated across the dynamic panel and the hazard battery, is directionally consistent with the critical-citizens hypothesis but never significant under MOC; support's protection should be read as additive, not conditional. (3) **Naive certainty**: across the battery, naive estimation produces significance that MOC extinguishes; every claim above survives uncertainty propagation, and several claims a naive analysis would have made do not.

Summary and Discussion

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